Digital Humanists' Help Desk:

Zine-ify Your Research

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Find these slides & other materials at https://bit.ly/rdds-zine-workshop

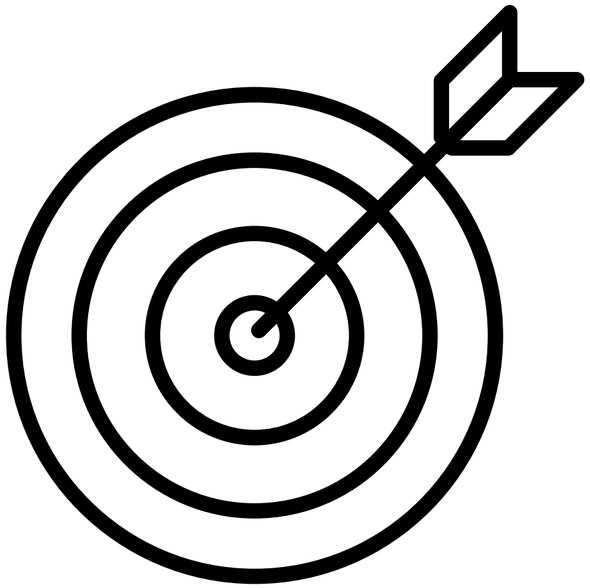
About Me

I'm **Cynthia Heider**, the Public Digital Scholarship Librarian at Penn Libraries.

I can help with:

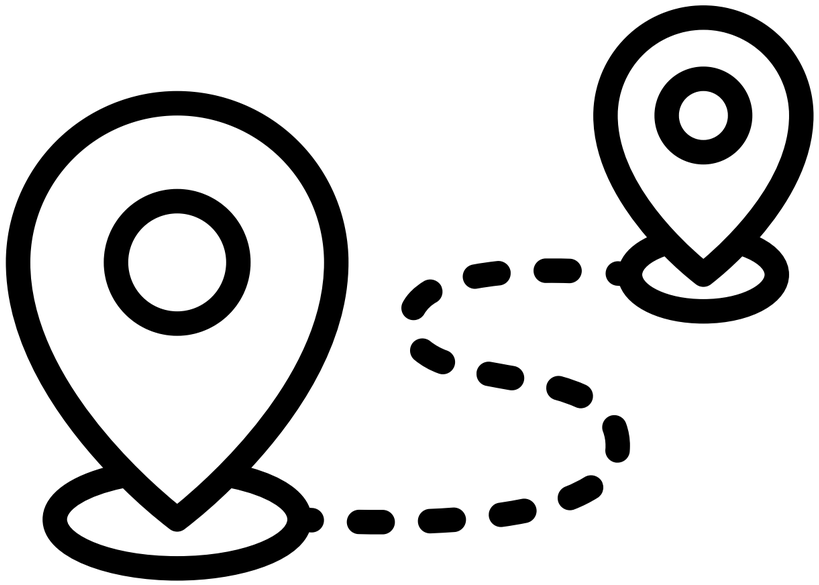
- Digital projects for public audiences
- Digital projects involving community partners
- Choosing the right tool or platform for your digital project
- Working with data in the humanities
- Connecting with digital project resources at and beyond UPenn

Workshop goals



- Understand the basics of zines and their use as a medium for researchers and academics
- Discuss the benefits and limitations of zines and different ways to create them
- Use simple tools to make your own zine!

Workshop Roadmap



- define zines and their attributes
- explore pros and cons of the zine medium for academics and researchers
- make a zine!

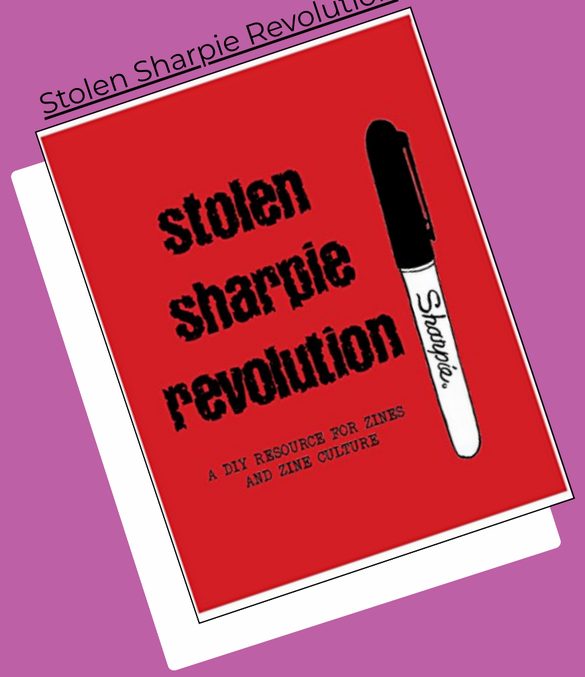
What is a zine?

"A zine, short for fanzine or magazine, is a DIY* subculture self-publication, usually made on paper and reproduced with a photocopier or printer. Zine creators are often motivated by a desire to share knowledge or experience with people in marginalized or otherwise less-empowered communities."

Barnard Zine Library

Origins

Stolen Sharpie Revolution



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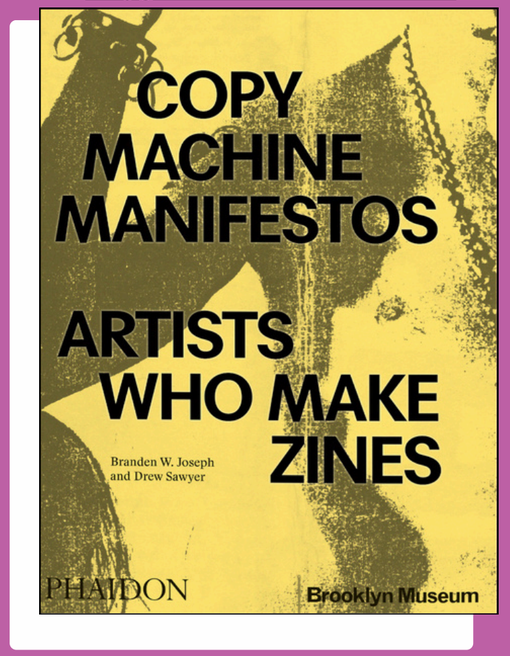
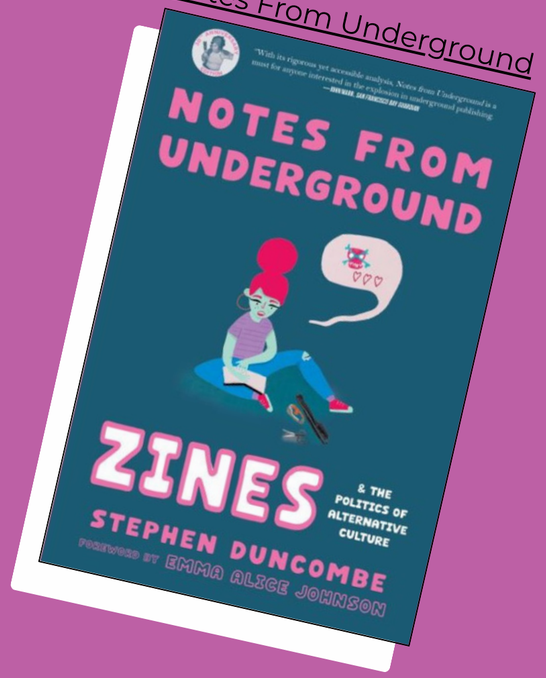
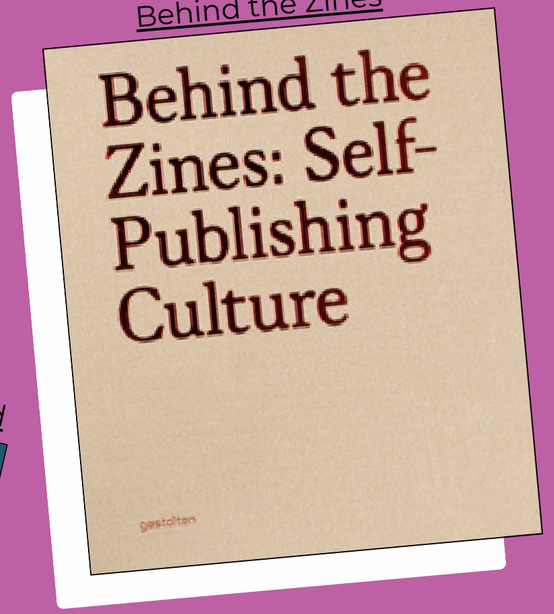


Notes From Underground



Behind the Zines



Attributes

self-published

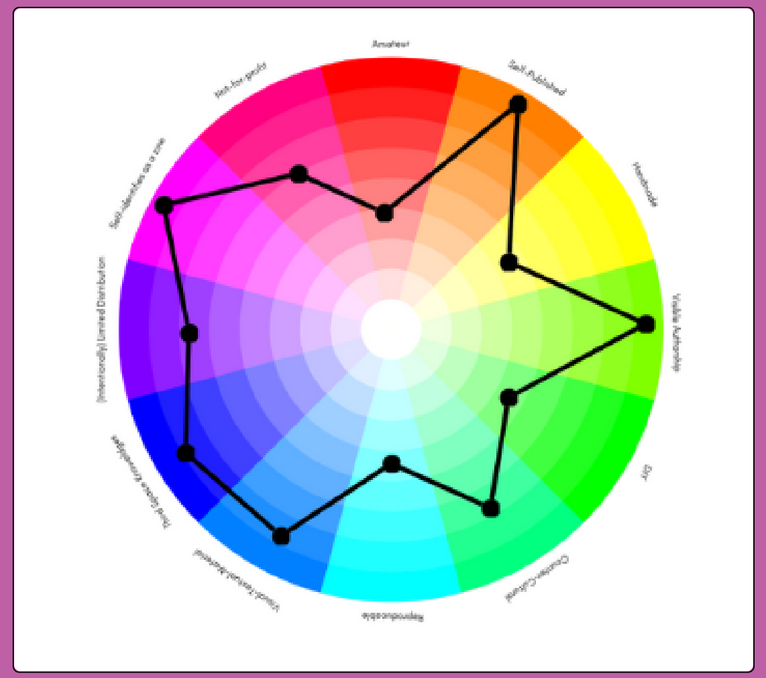
handmade

amateur

visual/textual/material

self-identifies as a zine

From "On the Zine Spectrum" in Zines 101 by Dr. Lea Cooper



counter-cultural

third space knowledges

visible authorship

not for profit

intentionally limited distribution

DIY

reproducible

Activity

Grab a zine (or two) from the pile! Take a couple of minutes to browse through it, then share what you notice about it. Some suggested things to look for include:

Authorship

Topic

Purpose

Rhetorical style & tone

Physical attributes

Audience

Copyright

Visual elements

Some zine subgenres

The Process Zine

exploring and explaining methods

The PerZine

bringing a personal perspective to a research topic

The Persuasion Zine

introducing recommended practices or calls-to action

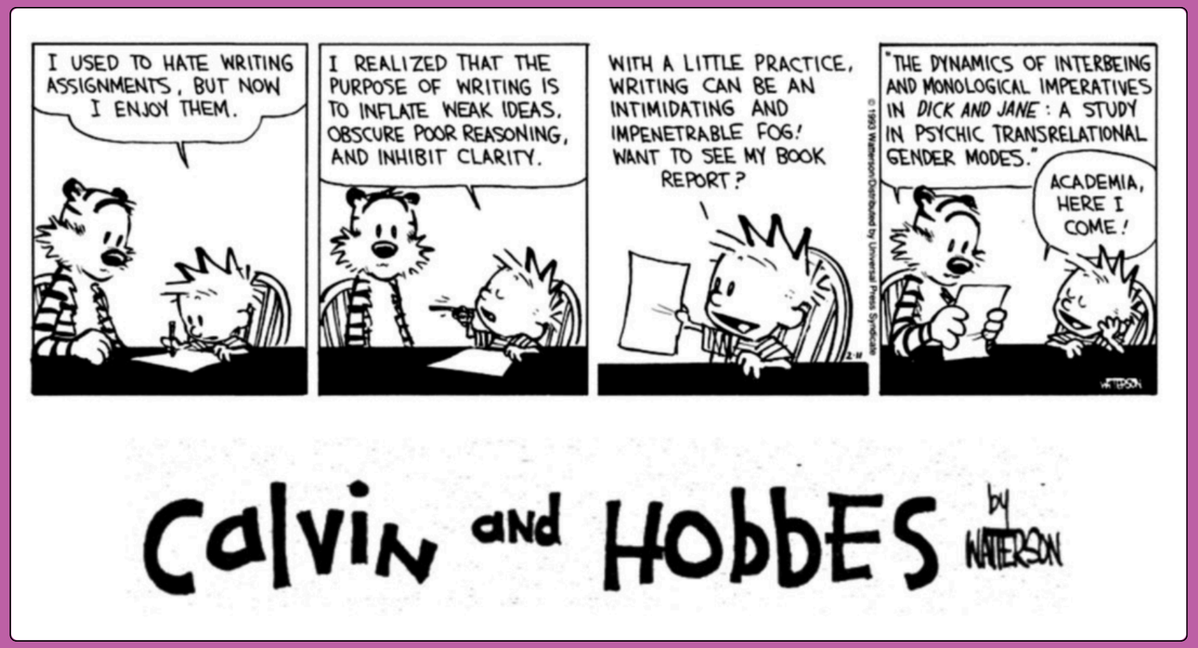
The Explainer Zine

demystifying what research is about and why it matters to a non-specialist

Why make zines?

"Traditional" academic outputs can be...

- Inaccessible
- Confining
- Exclusionary
- Ineffective



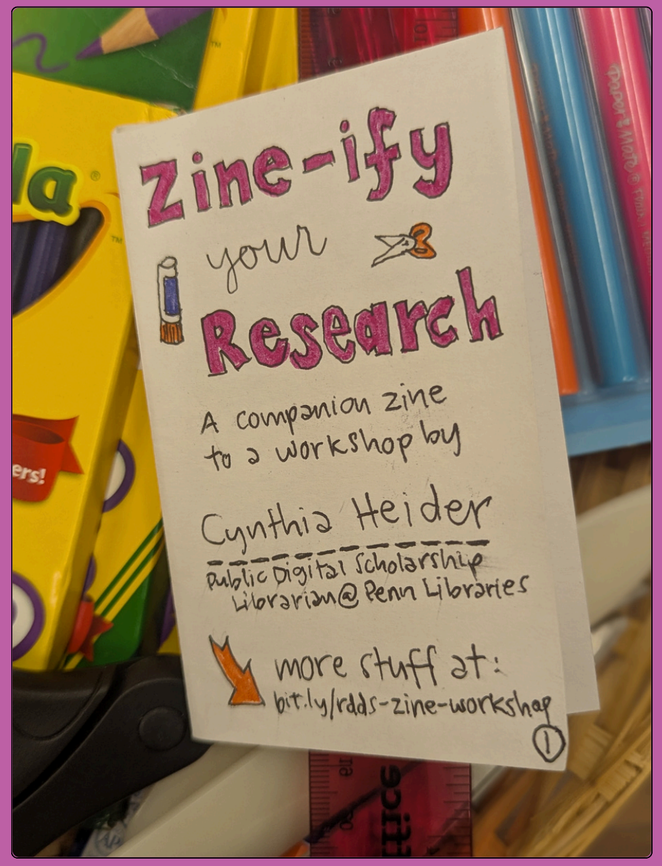
Activity

What will you write about? Your zine doesn't have to be about the entirety of your research. Choose a suggested prompt below and spend a few minutes jotting down some ideas. You can use this as your zine topic, or choose another, but this activity can help you get warmed up!

- What's challenging me right now in my research?
- What I wish I could tell my past or future self
- The story of my research journey so far
- My research in images and metaphors
- Questions I'm sitting with
- What I've discovered recently
- My research as a landscape or map
- The feeling of writing, analysis, or fieldwork
- Conversations in my head about my work

From "Cut, Paste , Create: Using Zines for Academic Writing" by Dr. Stephanie G. Zihms

Let's make a zine!



A suggested workflow

See the companion zine for more details!

- Outline your zine
- Choose your format
- Summarize what you want to say
- Add visual interest
- Don't forget the final touches
- Distribute your zine

Activity

Grab some supplies and start making your zine!

Some potential starting points:

- Start outlining or laying out your contents
- Doodle or draw a diagram or chart
- Sketch out a timeline
- Write down some key quotes
- Play with color to represent emotions or themes
- Replicate something you liked from the example zines

Trust your instincts!

Try out something new; you can always change it later!

No need to finish! There is no "right way"!

From "Cut, Paste , Create: Using Zines for Academic Writing" by Dr. Stephanie G. Zihms

What now?

Philly resources

Scholarly Commons (Penn's institutional repository)

4/28: Kelly Writers House Zine Fest (you can table here!)

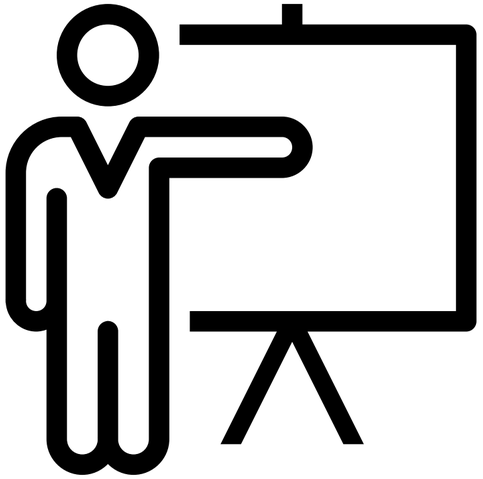
Annually in November: Philly Zine Fest

Philly Soapbox

East Falls Zine Reading Room

Iffy Books

Ulises Bookshop and Project Space



Survey

https://upenn.libwizard.com/f/rdds_survey_sp2026